

The world in brief

Catch up quickly on the global stories that matter



Photograph: Anadolu via Getty Images

Taiwan pushed for continued access to American military supplies in the aftermath of **Donald Trump's** meeting with **Xi Jinping**. Sales of American arms “serve as a mutual deterrence against regional threats”, said a Taiwanese government spokeswoman. Mr Trump had earlier said he would soon “make a determination” regarding [such sales](#), but “made no commitment either way”. [Few deals emerged](#) from the two-day Sino-American summit.

Tens of thousands of people gathered in **London** for two rival **marches**: one led by [Tommy Robinson](#), a far-right activist, the other marking the anniversary of the displacement of Palestinians when Israel was created in 1948. Police were expecting a very busy day—especially with the FA Cup final also taking place—but reported that the marches had passed “largely without significant incident”.

Abu-Bilal al-Minuki, a senior leader of Islamic State, was killed in a joint **Nigerian-American operation** in north-east Nigeria. Mr Minuki, whom Mr Trump described as “the most active terrorist in the world”, directed IS operations across the Sahel and west Africa. He was previously a prominent figure in another jihadist group,

Boko Haram, and was linked to the [mass kidnapping](#) of Nigerian schoolgirls in 2018.

The *uss **Gerald Ford***, the largest aircraft-carrier in the world, returned to port in Virginia after nearly a year at sea. The \$13bn ship was heavily involved in both [the mission to capture Nicolás Maduro](#) in Venezuela and the sorties against targets in Iran. Its deployment is the longest by an American carrier since the end of the Vietnam war.

Israel and Lebanon agreed to extend their ceasefire for 45 days, America's State Department said. It described talks between the two sides in Washington on Thursday and Friday as "highly productive"—despite almost daily reports of **Hizbullah** and Israel trading fire across southern Lebanon. Separately, an Israeli air strike in Gaza on Friday killed Izz al-Din al-Haddad, the commander of **Hamas's** armed wing, said to be an architect of the October 7th attacks.

America is reportedly preparing to indict **Raúl Castro**, Cuba's former leader, over the downing of two planes three decades ago. The move would further strain relations between the two countries, which are already at a low point. The Trump administration has imposed an oil blockade, among other measures, to bring about regime change in [Cuba](#). Mr Castro led the island for 15 years, until 2021.

Swatch stores around the world were forced to close as crowds of customers sought to buy the new Royal Pop watches made by Swatch and Audemars Piguet, two Swiss watchmakers. Long queues had formed in recent days of people eager for the much-hyped pop-art-inspired timepieces, priced at around \$400. Shops in Britain, France, India and the United Arab Emirates shut their doors.

Word of the week: *Darshan*, seeing that recognises the connection between all things. [Read our obituary](#) of Raghu Rai, India's most famous photojournalist.



Photograph: Reuters

America snaps back sanctions on Russian oil

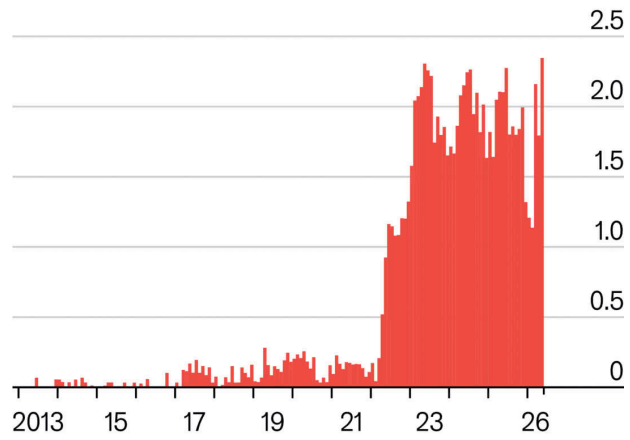
In March America allowed countries to buy Russian crude stranded at sea despite sanctions. The exemption was meant to ease petrol shortages caused by the closure of the Strait of Hormuz and push [oil prices](#) down globally. After two extensions, the waiver expires on Saturday.

India—which once sourced over 40% of its crude from the Gulf—has asked America to renew it. Before the Iran war America pressed India to curb purchases of Russian oil, and [India eventually complied](#). The waiver has changed things: Indian imports of Russian oil have soared since February, averaging a record 2.3m barrels per day so far in May.

Russian crude is similar in quality to common Gulf grades, making it easy for Indian refiners to process. There is little left to snap up: volumes of Russian oil at sea are at their lowest since August. But there are signs India has been stretching the waiver's terms. Ship-tracking data shows it has been buying Russian crude loaded after the waiver came into force.

Crude measure

India, crude-oil imports from Russia
m barrels per day



Source: Kpler



Photograph: Getty Images

The rise of Britain's far right

Tommy Robinson, a far-right activist known for his anti-Muslim bigotry, holds a rally in London on Saturday. Several figures have been barred from entering Britain to speak at the event, including an American influencer who torched the Koran with a flamethrower in a viral video. Mainstream politicians shun Mr Robinson. Commentators dismiss him as “marginal”. He is too toxic even for Nigel Farage, the right-wing populist who leads Reform UK. Only 14% of Britons have a positive view of him according to one survey.

But the rally highlights Mr Robinson's growing influence. YouGov, a pollster, finds that 29% of British men like him, up from 9% in 2021. Elon Musk, the world's richest man and owner of the social-media platform X, amplifies his message (and reportedly pays his legal fees). His last rally in September drew around 150,000 people, the largest organised by the far right in British history. Like him or not, Mr Robinson is [shaping views on Britain](#).



Photograph: AP

A bitter primary in Louisiana

On Saturday voters in Louisiana head to the polls for the state's fiercest Senate primary in years. Bill Cassidy, a two-term Republican senator and doctor from Baton Rouge, is defending his seat against a Trump-endorsed congresswoman and the state's more hardline treasurer. After voting to impeach Donald Trump in 2021, Mr Cassidy has been trying to win back the president's favour, voting with him "100% of the time" and even backing Robert F. Kennedy junior for health secretary after criticising his anti-scientific views. But Mr Trump never forgot. Now he is calling on Louisianans to vote the senator out.

The attack is part of Mr Trump's [broader revenge campaign](#) against incumbents who have crossed him. In the midst of an unpopular war abroad and soaring prices at home, the president is more focused on purifying his party than going after Democrats. Some Republicans worry he is diverting money and attention away from races they need to win to keep control of Congress.

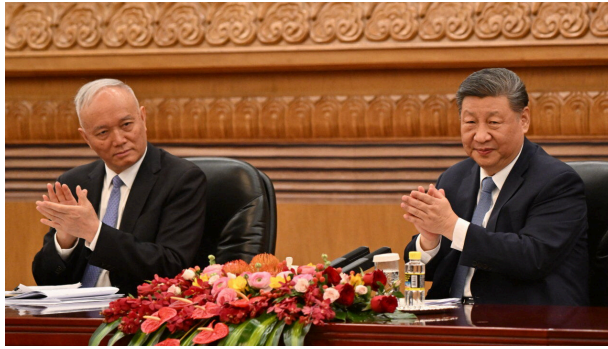


Photograph: EPA

The Vienna convention on undiplomatic relations

Eurovision's motto is "united by music". Over seven decades the song contest has certainly united viewers in joy as well as bemusement. For every "Waterloo" (1974) there has been an "Irlande Douze Points" (2008), screeched by Dustin the Turkey, a poultry puppet.

This year's final in Vienna on Saturday will not live up to the slogan. Iceland, Ireland, the Netherlands, Slovenia and Spain have not sent an entry in protest at Israel's participation. They object to [the war in Gaza](#), despite a ceasefire largely holding since October. Some of their national broadcasters will not even show the event. Things could be frostier, however. In November the inaugural Eurovision Song Contest Asia takes place in Bangkok. As recently as December soldiers from Thailand and Cambodia, two of the ten entrants, were killing each other in a [bitter border dispute](#). If that contest can create some amity between the two countries, it really will deserve *douze points*.



Photograph: Getty Images

Weekend profile: Cai Qi, China's second-most powerful man

In some photos of this week's meeting between Xi Jinping and Donald Trump, you can spot a tall, white-haired figure sitting to the right of the Chinese president. [Cai Qi](#) may be the second-most powerful person in China. As Mr Xi's right-hand man, in functional terms as well as seating plans, Mr Cai has insight into almost every area of policy and access to many of the Communist Party's secrets.

As chief of the party's powerful General Office, Mr Cai acts as Mr Xi's chief of staff, controlling his schedule and the people and information that reach him. But he also runs the body that implements leadership decisions and manages the party apparatus, and leads another that controls Mr Xi's personal security. Sometimes he even supervises Mr Xi's medical care.

The breadth and depth of Mr Cai's responsibilities is highly unusual. "Whenever people ask me, 'What happens if Xi were to drop dead tomorrow and there was no succession plan, who would get the top job?', Cai Qi seems like the obvious answer," says Jonathan Czin, a former China analyst at the CIA.

Born in the eastern province of Fujian in 1955, Mr Cai was sent to work in the countryside as a teenager, like Mr Xi, during the Cultural Revolution that raged across China between 1966 and

1976. When Mr Xi was posted to Fujian in 1985, Mr Cai was a junior official there. He later spent some 15 years working closely with Mr Xi in Fujian and neighbouring Zhejiang province.

His big break came in 2014 when Mr Xi brought him to Beijing to join the National Security Commission, a secretive body believed to include spies, generals and police chiefs. Within three years, Mr Cai was elevated to the Politburo, the party's top 25 leaders, despite not having previously been in the broader Central Committee. He then became mayor and later party chief of Beijing, where he appears to have impressed Mr Xi. He was also an energetic advocate of absolute loyalty to China's leader. That helps to explain his unusual appointment in 2023 to lead the General Office soon after joining the Politburo Standing Committee.

All of that suggests that the president values him as a hard-nosed enforcer and administrator. More importantly, he is not seen as a threat, as his swift promotion from relative obscurity means he does not have his own political powerbase. Instead, he derives his authority entirely through his relationship with Mr Xi.

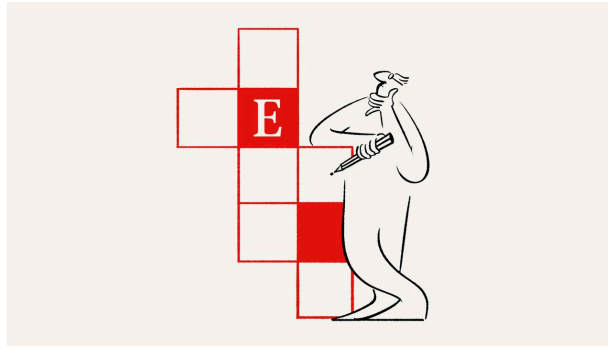


Illustration: The Economist

Mini crossword

We publish a new interactive edition of our crossword daily, allowing you to enter and check the answers and see explanations. Try it [here](#). Or, if you prefer, use the clues below.

There are two sets of clues, one for seasoned cruciverbalists and the other for less experienced solvers. Both give the same answers.

Cryptic clues

1 across - Flat, even if you spell it backwards (5)

2 across - Laura confused hearing (5)

3 across - Minor thought: what's my point? (5)

1 down - Tacit loan wiped out for milk production (9)

Straight clues

1 across - Flush; a stage in a computer game (5)

2 across - Relating to the ear or the sense of hearing (5)

3 across - Boreal, “up” on a map usually (5)

1 down - The process of producing and secreting milk (9)



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

The winners of this week's quiz

Thank you to everyone who took part in this week's quiz. The winners, chosen at random, were:

Yu Zhang, Mosman, Australia

Ayako Fukui, Singapore

Erik Mashkilleyson, Helsinki, Finland

They gave the correct answers of Leonardo da Vinci, Bill Clinton, Babe Ruth, Albert Einstein and Sir Paul McCartney. The theme is that they are all left-handed.

The questions were:

Monday: Which Renaissance artist had a sideline as a military engineer for Cesare Borgia?

Tuesday: Which American president was born in a town called Hope?

Wednesday: The departure of which baseball player in 1920 is supposed to have resulted in a long-lasting curse on the Boston Red Sox?

Thursday: Which famous physicist produced some of his most important work while employed at the Swiss patent office?

Friday: Which musician sang a duet with Stevie Wonder called “Ebony and Ivory”?

*You must write, and read, as if
your life depended on it.*

Andrienne Rich